turner. The kid, already scared, couldn't do much with it. That's when Mohtashim Rasheed turned around and said, 'From today, you're only going to bowl spin. This fast-cum-spin thing you're doing is your style now. But fix your stupid dance. And remember: mix it up.'

From that day onwards, I continued bowling that way. At the U-14 level, I was selected as a bowler. But the batting bug remained in me. I could deliver with the blade from time to time – some of it had to do with my strength. I remember in a club game, I once went out to bat at No. 7 and slammed a century. I even took three wickets in that match. It was a proper cricket ground, quite large, and I hit a lot of sixes in that match. Professor Siraj-ul-Islam Bukhari, a legend in the Karachi City Cricket Association, was watching that game. He later called me over and asked, 'Those were some big sixes. Are you really a U-14 player?' By then, I had got used to the question and replied, 'Sir, all Pashtuns are strong. You need to make a ball of stone, not cork, if you want me to hit smaller sixes!'